

The Mentors: Wheeler, Zel'dovich, Sciama

Who were these youths who revolutionized our understanding of black holes? Most of them were students, postdocs, and intellectual "grandchildren" of three remarkable master teachers: John Archibald Wheeler in Princeton, New Jersey, U.S.A.; Yakov Borisovich Zel'-dovich in Moscow, Russia, D.S.S.R.; and Dennis Sciama in Cambridge, England, U.K. Through their intellectual progeny, Wheeler, Zel'-dovich, and Sciama put their personal stamps on our modern understanding of black holes.

Each of these mentors had his own style. In fact, styles more different are hard to find. Wheeler was a charismatic, inspirational visionary. Zel'dovich was the hard-driving player/coach of a tightly knit team. Sciama was a self-sacrificing catalyst. We shall meet each of them in turn in the following pages.

How well I recall my first meeting with Wheeler. It was September 1962, two years before the advent of the golden age. Wheeler was a recent convert to the concept of a black hole, and I, at twenty-two years of age, had just graduated from Caltech and come to Princeton to pursue graduate study toward a Ph.D. My dream was to work on relativity research under